Eight Questions Families Ask Before a Husband's Care Arrangement Changes

General answers in plain words, and who to ask when the question is about him.

When a husband's care is about to change, the same questions come up in most families, often late in the evening with nobody to put them to. These are eight of them, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about your husband in particular. Where a question needs someone who has assessed him, the answer says who to take it to.

1 When will he need someone with him?

That depends on him, so it's the care team's question to answer. What you can do is ask it in a form they can answer. Medicare's discharge checklist asks families to mark the everyday activities that need help: bathing, dressing, using the bathroom, climbing stairs, meals, getting to appointments. Set each one beside the part of the day it falls in, and ask the staff which of them need someone there. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell from what you've been told which parts of the day or night he'll need someone. Ask the discharge planner or the nurse to go through an ordinary day with you.

2 Everyone says they'll help. How do I find out who is actually available?

Ask each person for days and times. The Family Caregiver Alliance says that when you break the jobs down into very simple tasks it is easier for people to help, and AARP's planning guide suggests each person consider what they are prepared, and not prepared, to do. Then write down what was agreed. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that a written agreement at the end of a family meeting can be a helpful reminder for everyone. [2] [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the conversation keeps snagging on family history. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that a third-party facilitator can help when one is needed.

3 Who covers the nights?

Nights are easy to leave out of a plan made in daylight, so give them their own line. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests asking the discharge team directly: does he need help at night and, if so, how will I get enough sleep? Whether he needs someone overnight is for the people who assess him. Who would be there is for the family to write down, by name. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** nobody has told you whether he'll need help overnight. Ask the discharge planner or the nurse, and ask what the plan is if he does.

4 What counts as backup?

Backup is the named answer to “and if that person can't come?” AARP's planning guide says team members need not all live nearby or have huge blocks of time to be of value, and that a wide team helps make sure you still have support when someone's ability to help changes. For a break of your own there is a word, respite: temporary care intended to give time off to the person who provides care on a regular basis. [3] [6] [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** there is nobody to name. AARP's guide says a nurse or social worker can help you work out what is needed and find services, and the Eldercare Locator, a public service of the federal Administration for Community Living, connects families to local resources at 1-800-677-1116.

5 I'm the one who'll be doing most of it. Do my own limits count?

Yes, and the discharge team is meant to hear them. The Family Caregiver Alliance says discharge planners should discuss with you your willingness and ability to provide care, and that it is extremely important to tell the discharge staff about any limitations you have, physical or otherwise. Saying what you can keep up is information the plan needs. It isn't a complaint. [5] [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're being counted on for something you haven't been shown how to do, or can't keep doing. Medicare's checklist says to talk to the staff, before discharge, about the help and training you need.

6 Which of my worries should go to a professional before the move?

Anything about falls, his medicines, how much supervision he needs or the place he's going. This page can't sort those for you, and they aren't for the family to settle on its own. The CDC tells family caregivers to talk openly with the healthcare provider about fall risks, and MedlinePlus says to ask the provider all of your questions about his medicines. Write each worry as a question, and note who you gave it to. [8] [9]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're not sure a worry is worth mentioning. Mention it, and let them decide.

7 He's coming home. Is it our job to decide whether the house is safe?

No. Your job is to describe it. Write down the specific things you've noticed and where they are; the CDC's home checklist for older adults names the kind of thing a family can note, such as objects on the stairs, throw rugs, cords across a walkway or a dark path from the bed to the bathroom. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests asking the discharge team whether someone will come to the home to do an assessment. [10] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've noted something and can't tell whether it matters. Give the list to the discharge planner, the nurse or the therapist.

8 If we've mapped the week and written our questions, is the plan cleared?

No. A filled-in page shows what you know: the hours, the names and the open questions. It isn't a safety clearance, and a question you've passed to the care team isn't settled until they answer it. If things seem to be moving faster than the answers, the Family Caregiver Alliance says it is reasonable to ask the discharge planning team to slow things down so nothing is overlooked. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a question you handed over hasn't come back with an answer. Ask the person you gave it to where it stands.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your husband himself, and it doesn't say whether any arrangement is safe. Anything that depends on his condition, his medicines or how much supervision he needs belongs to someone who has assessed him.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where they become about your husband: it asks about his needs, his safety and the people helping, one area at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
6. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
7. Administration for Community Living, Eldercare Locator
8. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Family Caregivers: Protect Your Loved Ones from Falling (STEADI brochure, 2018)
9. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregiving - medication management: MedlinePlus Medical Encyclopedia
10. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Check for Safety: A Home Fall Prevention Checklist for Older Adults (STEADI brochure, 2018)
